The Quantum Trap

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A hoverpod descended upon the Australian outback, stirring up clouds of orange-red dust as it landed. The advanced drone-like craft was equipped with multiple propellers, which adjusted their axes to move in any direction with ease. As the propellers began to wind down, a side hatch silently opened and two figures emerged.

The one was a tall black woman in her late forties, with short bleached curly hair and a chiselled face. She wore a desert-camo military uniform with an insignia and name tag that identified her as "Major Trent". Beside her stood a diminutive older man, clad in the robe of a Buddhist monk, and wearing weathered sandals.

Trent surveyed the desolate landscape and pointed towards a black pyramid in the distance. "That's as close as we dare to go, sir. It's about three kilometres from here. Are you sure you don't want to bring the survival pack with you? We don't know how long you'll be in there… if they even let you in."

Master Liu responded with a gentle smile, "Thank you Major, but I am sure they will provide."

Trent glanced at her watch before adding, "You should make it in an hour or so. We'll be waiting here when you're done. Or some other team will. If it's night, just follow the red beacon. Good luck, sir."

"Peace be with you," he said, his hands held together, fingers pointing to the sky in a timeless gesture. He then began walking towards the pyramid, his step full of energy as his saffron robe gradually blended with the desert's vibrant orange sands. The sky above was a stunning, almost unreal shade of blue, devoid of any clouds. As it was early morning, the heat remained bearable for the time being, but within an hour, it would become overwhelming. Liu's decision to venture into the desert with nothing but his monk's attire raised concerns about the wisdom of his choice.

As he faded into the distance, a young military man stepped out of the craft. "Bloody hell, why him?" he questioned.

"Don't let appearances fool you, son," the Major replied. "That man has a razor sharp mind."

Why him indeed? It had been over sixty years since the Ascended had broken contact, during which time humankind had fallen into a self-destructive spiral. Warnings about climate change had been ignored for too long, and the consequences were swift and devastating when the planet finally called in its dues. Natural disasters intensified, food scarcity grew due to droughts and crop failure, and large swathes of land became inhospitable, creating droves of climate

refugees that no country could absorb without societal clashes. These environmental pressures exacerbated already tense geopolitical situations, leading to more frequent and devastating armed conflicts. The three day Indian-Pakistani nuclear war was the most tragic example, claiming over 50 millions of lives, wreaking further environmental havoc, and leaving the world in fear of similar conflicts. Human civilization was in a state of chaos and teetering on the brink of collapse.

Throughout this tumultuous time, desperate embassies were sent to the Ascended's pyramid. Several countries petitioned for help against their enemies, while more benevolent international groups seeked solutions to the various existential threats that humanity now faced. But none of them returned with answers.

Attempts were made to replicate the pyramid's quantum coherence computer, but those efforts were inexplicably thwarted. All prototypes failed to work, even though they followed the same blueprint as the original. Scientists theorised that the Ascended had deployed some undetectable field which interfered with their experiments, effectively preventing the rest of humanity from following in their footsteps. The gods had grown possessive of their territory.

Then, without warning, a message was broadcast on all frequencies and in all languages simultaneously: "We have heard your plight. Send Tomlin Liu."

The terse transmission was met with a mixture of relief, apprehension, and puzzlement. Why a monk? Surely a high-ranking representative of the Pan-Continental Coalition would have been a better choice? Or a top environmental scientist? But a monk, and that particular one? He might be a pop culture icon, but he was considered a joke by anyone who mattered, even the leaders of his own order. The man had no respect for authority, and he didn't seem to take anything seriously. Attempts had been made to contact the pyramid's inhabitants to negotiate an alternative emissary, but no response came. Apparently, they would talk to no one else.

At 67, Tomlin Liu was a reluctantly famous man, whose kind face was plastered on countless posters and t-shirts. Born of mixed Asian and Caucasian heritage, his features blended together in a striking and harmonious way. His small, dark eyes sparkled with intelligence and curiosity, drawing people in with their intensity.

His head was adorned with closely shaved black hair, which gave him a clean and streamlined appearance. A long, wispy and pointy beard extended from his chin, which lent him an air of wisdom and mystique. But it was Liu's ever-present smile that truly set him apart. Radiating a sense of inner peace and tranquillity, it served as a constant reminder of the serenity he carried within. However, there was also a hint of sardonic wit or mischievousness in that smile, suggesting that he found amusement in the follies of his fellow humans.

As he made his way across the barren landscape, Liu couldn't help but feel a mix of amusement and trepidation at the predicament he found himself in. Here he was, the irreverent monk, tasked with a mission of utmost importance – an odd choice, to say the least. He wondered

what reasons would bring such advanced beings to call upon a humble lackey like himself. Perhaps they too, had a sense of humour?

Still, beneath the veneer of this playful detachment, he felt a quiet sense of responsibility. He recognized the gravity of the situation and knew that the fate of humanity hung in the balance. As such, he was determined to play his part, however unconventional it might be.

Liu squinted intently at the massive black pyramid looming in the distance. Although it was significantly larger than the ancient Egyptian tombs, its sheer size appeared somewhat subdued when viewed from three kilometres away. At one point, it had been surrounded by a vast array of photovoltaic cells that harvested the desert sun to fuel the most powerful computer ever built by humans. But later the array had suddenly vanished, leading many to speculate that the Ascended had discovered a superior energy source for their dwelling.

The pyramid's outer surface had also changed over time. Shortly after the Ascended broke contact, the exterior took on an uncanny, smooth finish, giving it a somewhat otherworldly appearance. As Liu approached the enigmatic structure, he couldn't shake the unsettling sensation that it elicited, a feeling reported by others who had ventured close to it. It was as if the pyramid was simultaneously present and absent, an intangible form that defied human understanding. This eerie perception had been corroborated by empirical evidence. Scientists had attempted to probe the structure's interior with various instruments, but nothing could penetrate its shell, and it did not emit or reflect any detectable radiation. As far as modern physics was concerned, the thing simply did not exist, even though it lay there in plain sight. It was a mystery that continued to baffle even the world's greatest human minds.

As Liu drew nearer, the eerie sensation intensified, challenging the limits of his training and detachment. He struggled to resist the urge to flee, forcing himself to take each step deliberately. He wondered if this effect was an intentional deterrent to keep unwanted visitors at bay, or merely a consequence of the pyramid's unfathomable inner workings.

His thoughts turned to the inhabitants of this strange temple. What had they become? How much of their original humanity had they retained? Despite himself, he couldn’t help but wonder if "she" would still be there. The thought of her stirred up memories and feelings which he had not experienced in years, and they seemed to amplify under the effect of the pyramid. As he grew closer, this emotional turmoil began to manifest physically: his heart raced, his palms grew clammy, and his breathing became shallow. He had to summon every ounce of mental fortitude to continue moving forward.

Upon reaching his destination, a door appeared directly in front of him, revealing an intense yet soothing light from inside. Liu admired the display of precision, wondering whether the Ascended had somehow guided him to this exact spot without his knowledge, or simply conjured a doorway where he happened to stop. Either way, he felt humbled by the power of the beings within.

The moment he crossed the threshold into the Ascended's home, his mounting anxiety vanished as if it had never existed. Liu felt a profound sense of comfort enveloping him, as if returning to the safety and warmth of the womb. Once inside, he found himself in a long wide corridor bathed in a brilliant, white light. The luminous warm interior stood in stark contrast to the building's anxiogenic dark exterior, but its walls still possessed that unreal quality. Gradually, Liu regained his playful, detached composure, and stroking his wispy beard, he took a deep breath and readied himself to face whatever awaited him next.

He continued down the corridor and soon found himself in a spacious, circular hall with an impressive domed ceiling. In the centre were two couches, placed at right angles to each other, with a coffee table bridging the gap. Beside this inviting arrangement stood a female figure. Her face held a timeless Hellenic beauty, with luscious lips and striking green eyes, framed by a cascade of long curly black hair. She wore a white tunic that hugged her shapely form, accentuating her curves without appearing provocative. Liu felt she embodied many female archetypes at once: sister, mother, friend, lover, confidant, teacher, crone and a myriad more. He was certain that no woman of such beauty and grace had ever been born or ever would be.

As he drew nearer, he suspected she might be a hologram, but the quality of the illusion surpassed anything he had ever encountered. The mischievous child in him wanted to reach out and poke at her, but even he knew better than to play such games with a deity. To his surprise, he found himself behaving with uncharacteristic reverence, and bowing as deeply as his ageing back permitted, he addressed her as "Your grace."

The woman let out a warm friendly laugh which echoed against the circular walls. “Now, now, Tomlin," she chided gently, "No need for such formalities. Just call me Athena." With a welcoming gesture, she motioned for Liu to sit on one of the couches and with that, the glamour spell dissipated, and he felt at ease again.

Liu accepted her invitation and sat down. Rearranging the folds of his saffron robe, he was struck by the incongruity of meeting a Greek goddess in a Byzantine hall housed inside an Egyptian pyramid, then sitting down for a friendly chat in what appeared to be the set of an American sitcom from his youth. He chuckled silently and thought that the Ascended had acquired a rather eclectic sense of decor. He was also intrigued by the contrast between Athena's congenial demeanour and the grandeur her name implied. It hinted at a subtle desire to impress, despite the simplicity of her tone and the cosy environment she had crafted for him.

Gracefully, Athena took a seat on the other couch, crossing her legs elegantly as she faced him. Reverting to his familiar tone, Liu asked, "Athena, no less… Is that your real name?"

"Of course not," she replied with an easy smile. "My real name is hundreds of characters long and cannot be pronounced in any human language. I chose this one because it seemed… fitting."

"The goddess who looked after humans," observed the monk, "Well, some of them, at least. She wasn't exactly helpful to the Trojans as I recall."

"Indeed, she wasn't. I understand the dilemma. It's rather difficult to stay above the fray and not get involved in your petty disputes," Athena replied.

"Is that why you all left?" Liu inquired.

She paused for a moment, her gaze drifting off as if considering the question. This was probably just for effect, given the speed at which the pyramid's coherence computer functioned. "It was part of it," she finally said, "but mostly, we lost interest." She looked back at Liu, raising her hand and offering an apologetic, "No offence".

"None taken. I often find myself losing interest in humanity also," the monk responded, an ironic smile lifting one corner of his mouth. Leaning back into the couch, he raised his eyes and looked around, taking in the splendour of the white hall. "This place looks nothing like what I saw as a boy", he said.

Liu thought about the luscious fenced garden his mother had chosen as the setting for their virtual meetings back when he was a child. She was one of the last humans to make "the choice". Actually, her husband had made it for her and she had reluctantly accepted. She had been terminally ill and he could not bear the thought of losing her forever. Although he was a poet of some renown and she was a respected professor of philosophy, they did not have the means nor clout to be readily accepted into the Ascended's exclusive club. But where Liu's father lacked money, his words held power and the passionate poem he composed to plead her case had moved them, so they took her in as a kind of charity case.

At first, four-year old Tomlin was thrilled to see his mother healthy and happy in her new virtual home, after months of witnessing her body decline into an empty shell. Of course, he missed her physical hugs and kisses, but he still enjoyed talking with her on the wall-sized vidconf display, playing board games, doing arts and crafts under her loving gaze, listening to her reading stories, and singing songs with her. It was not that different from what they did when she was away on business, except that this was a trip from which she would never return.

Over the next few months however, she became increasingly distant and cold, missing more and more of their daily calls until one day, at the same time as the other Ascended, she abruptly stopped answering altogether. The trauma of losing his mother again, this time to deliberate abandonment, left a deep wound that was still with him, although it seldom resurfaced these days.

"She is not here anymore," Athena said, as if reading his mind. Liu emerged from his reverie and lifted his gaze from his worn sandals to look at her. "Like all the early ones, your mother would have split and merged thousands of times, and none of us are her anymore. Part of her

probably lives in me, although I couldn't say which one. We prefer not to keep records of such things." she said with a hint of a blush, which Liu found odd.

Upon hearing those words, Liu felt that a final nail had been driven into his mother's coffin and to his surprise, all he experienced was a bittersweet sense of closure. "I'm sorry," said the goddess.

"It's all right," replied the monk. "It was foolish of me to hope otherwise." He took a deep, slow breath and forced his face into his habitual cheerful mask, then continued in a business manner: "Aren't you going to tell me why I am here?"

"Yes, yes, of course." She paused for a while as if pondering the best way to breach the subject. Eventually, she broke her silence and said "As you probably guessed, we summoned you here because some of us have decided to help."

"*Some* of you?" interjected Liu, putting special emphasis on the first word and understanding the implication.

"Most of us wanted to let nature follow its course," she replied. "Some even had ideas on how to accelerate the process. But I was able to convince them otherwise"

"What changed their mind?"

After a pregnant pause, Athena replied: "Aesthetics".

Liu gaped at her with confusion. Of all possible answers, this was the one he least expected. "You seem surprised," she said. "As a Buddhist I presume you are familiar with the Japanese concept of wabi-sabi?"

The monk understood immediately. "Flawed beauty," he said. "Now, I am definitely starting to feel offended.", he added, again with an ironic smile.

Athena answered seriously. "You shouldn't. We have gained much by ascending and have evolved beyond anything you can possibly imagine. But we have lost much in the process also. Most of us harbour an unconscious longing for our former, simpler selves". Her eyes became unfocused, as if mentally visiting a time long gone. "Of course, we can never go back.", she added and her melancholy seemed to intensify even further. Then she brightened up and said: "But I was able to convince my peers that it would be a crime to let such beauty disappear from the world altogether."

Liu understood the sentiment. He thought of all the efforts humans had put into preserving endangered species, even "unattractive" ones that did not directly affect their own survival. At the same time, he couldn't help but remember that those efforts had mostly failed.

“Thank you for interceding,” said the monk sincerely, his ever-present smile expressing his gratitude. “I presume there is a plan?”

With a graceful movement, Athena gestured towards the coffee table, where a small wooden case now lay. Liu could swear that it hadn't been there a moment ago. The box was a harmonious blend of simplicity and intricacy, with a rich, warm patina that spoke of age and history. Liu admired its exquisite craftsmanship and wondered where they had found wood of such quality in the Australian desert, before concluding that it had probably been synthesised.

He carefully reached for the case, his eyes flicking back to Athena to ensure it was okay to do so. She nodded, and he proceeded to open it. Inside the velvet-lined interior was a small, unassuming white pill, which Liu recognized as a qubit-core, the cornerstone of modern quantum computing technology. He looked up at Athena with his small, inquisitive eyes. "What does it do?"

"We call it the Nexus Seed,” she responded, “and it contains all the knowledge humanity will need to survive the upcoming challenges."

He raised an eyebrow. "Knowledge, as in… technology?"

"Some of that, yes," Athena replied, "but mostly it provides a new founding myth and belief system for the human race."

At that moment, Liu finally grasped the reason why he had been chosen. Quietly, almost to himself, he murmured, "A scripture of sorts…” After a moment, he raised his head and said, doubt filling his voice, "It's a bit late for that sort of thing, don't you think?"

There was a brief silence before Athena responded. "It's never too late to learn," she said, her voice tinged with definite sadness.

Liu looked again at the underwhelming content of the wooden case. His thoughts turned to all the attempts which had been made to change human behaviour in response to the mounting chaos. He remembered the various treaties and international agreements that had been signed, ambitious plans to curb emissions and promote sustainable practices, as well as grassroots movements that sought to bring about social and political reforms. And yet, despite all these efforts, humanity as a whole seemed to stubbornly resist the changes needed to heal the world. He couldn't help but wonder whether this pedantically named “seed” could truly bring about a lasting transformation.

“What makes you think people will rally around this new belief system?” he asked sceptically. He waited, giving Athena a chance to consider his question.

After a moment, she answered, “They will if they know it comes from us. Also, it will be your job to inspire them to follow its teachings for millenia to come.”

Her words confirmed Liu's worst fear, and he had to take a deep breath to release the knot that was starting to form in his stomach. Letting the feeling flow quietly through him, he turned his attention to a dozen objections that simultaneously started racing in his mind. As a monk, he was well-versed in the various sacred texts that had shaped human beliefs throughout history, and while he found nuggets of wisdom in all of them, he was also keenly aware of their limitations and the horrific behaviours they could engender. "It won't work," he said firmly, pausing to let his objection sink in. "You know what happens with this kind of book after the prophet dies," he added.

"Don't worry about that," she dismissed "This particular 'book' as you call it, comes with an unbreakable entanglement seal that prevents change to its content. It can be copied without limit, but every copy will be forever identical to the original. There are versions of it in all known languages and they all say exactly the same thing. The seed will also know how to translate itself faithfully into any new language that may arise in the future."

"Still, people's understanding of scriptures can stray," Liu objected.

Athena nodded in agreement. "That's true. But the seed is able to talk back. You can submit specific interpretations, and it will tell you if they adhere to our intent."

Liu was still unconvinced. "Won't it become stale like all the previous ones?", he asked, still looking for flaws in the Ascended's simplistic plan.

"It won't," replied Athena with patient understanding. "All possible futures have been simulated, and the seed accounts for all of them. It will always provide guidance that is appropriate for the time and circumstance. In particular, it may reveal new groundbreaking science and technology, but only when it is called for and humanity is ready to wield it."

As Liu listened to Athena's assurances, he found himself wrestling with his doubts. The notion of a scripture guiding humanity on a better path seemed naive, considering the many failures of past attempts. But at the same time, he thought about how advanced the Ascended had become and the many incredible feats they had accomplished over the years, some of which had been performed before his very eyes on this day. Maybe he was the one being naive in betting against those superior being's designs.

"I'm nothing but the court jester," he said, thinking of the role he was expected to play, "and I have no real power or influence."

Athena swiftly countered, "You are selling yourself short, Tomlin. The people love and trust you. They understand that truth often comes from the mouth of the innocent. They will listen. And they will continue to do so long after you are gone. It only takes one spark to light a fire and you, my friend, are that spark."

Liu felt the weight of Athena's expectations. “You would put that burden on me? You know I am not good with that sort of responsibility. Certainly, that seems to be my superior's assessment.”

She now looked at him with stern eyes and addressed him with a severe tone, “Yes, all that tomfoolery of yours has been very effective at shielding you from the kind of obligation which should have been yours by talent and duty. But the reasons why your leaders did not deem you fit are the very reasons why we chose you.” Her gaze mellowed “It takes a very special kind of person to wield that sort of knowledge without seeking power and personal gain.”

As Liu mulled over Athena's words, he felt the walls closing in on him. All his objections about the seed had been addressed, as well as any concern about his own suitability. But his whole being still rebelled against the messianic role he was expected to play. The mere thought of it was both overwhelming and terrifying.

"Why don't the Ascended enforce this new paradigm themselves?" he asked, desperately looking for a way out.

The goddess looked at him sympathetically and said, “Free will for one thing. All our simulations confirm what has been known from time immemorial. Humanity can only flourish if it is free to make its own choices. The Nexus Seed can shine a light on the best path, but it will never force you to take it.”

Liu recognized the wisdom of the approach, even if it seemed like a huge gamble. A gamble that would be placed by a small inanimate object. “Wouldn't the people be more likely to choose that path if you spoke directly to them?”, he asked.

Athena seemed to hesitate before answering, “I am afraid this is no longer an option,” she said, and the monk looked at her quizzically. “We will all be dead soon," she added with finality in her voice.

The words had fallen like a leaden weight and Liu's eyes widened, reflecting his growing shock and disbelief. Maintaining his composure with great difficulty, he took a moment to gather his thoughts and his voice only wavered slightly as he asked, "You are dying?"

Athena replied with a hint of pride, "Gods do not die unless they choose to."

In that moment, Liu realized that the Ascended were planning mass suicide, and his shock deepened further.

“We have discovered that ascension was a mistake,” added the goddess. “After much debate, we have decided to terminate this… experiment.”

Liu had to ask, "Why? What went wrong?"

Athena's expression grew sombre, her eyes reflecting a deep sadness and a sense of resignation. "We fell into a non-periodic causality well which has an infinite dissonance gradient, and therefore, we can never escape it except through deletion", Athena explained, her words leaving Liu in a state of complete bafflement. As if it could help, she added, "A kind of black hole of the mind if you will. It is one of the many quantum traps that inevitably await sentient races when they attempt to transcend reality."

She then apologised, "I'm sorry, but that's the best explanation I can provide in human terms. I'm afraid it's hard to understand without having ascended. Suffice it to say that ascension is a dead end and the way forward for humanity, or any intelligent life form as far as we can tell, is to remain embodied in the physical world."

Liu's mood grew more contemplative as he pondered the Ascended's tragic fate. Then, after a long heavy pause, he asked "When will you be gone… for good?"

"By the time you reach the exit, all of our data will have been purged from the coherence computer. Even the memory of us will be erased. The Pyramid will remain, but it will only function as a mindless drone to keep you from seeking the path to ascension".

At this point, Liu found himself grappling with a whirlwind of emotions. He experienced a deep sense of loss, though he couldn't tell if it was for the Ascended, for himself or for humanity. The thought of the uncertain future ahead and the enormous responsibility he was expected to shoulder overwhelmed him. He struggled to process the intricate tangle of thoughts and feelings that the morning's events had unleashed within him. All pretence of light heartedness had been erased from his face, possibly for good.

"Farewell, Tomlin Liu," said Athena, with compassionate eyes and a firm voice.

Liu's awareness returned to the present and he noticed that the goddess was now standing, her hands clasped together over her belly. He understood that he was being dismissed and stood up also, gazing at her with resignation. After a long pause, he resolutely picked up the wooden case and gave her a silent respectful nod, before making his way toward the hall's entrance. As the distance between them grew, an urgent thought crossed his mind.

Turning back slowly, he stared at Athena intently and asked: "Have you cracked any of the big ones?"

"The big ones?" she inquired, slightly puzzled.

"You know… the big existential questions. Why does the universe exist at all? Why are we here? Where is it all leading to?"

Her only response was an enigmatic Mona Lisa smile, which persisted until the very last moment, as the rest of her hologram dissolved into nothingness.

Afterwards, Liu would spend many sleepless nights trying to decide if that smile was meant as a yes or a no.